A few Nobel Prizes were awarded to physicists who happened to resolve other problems, almost by mistake, during the course of their attempts to disentangle the puzzle of quantum gravity. Two Dutch physicists, Gerard't Hooft and Martinus Veltman, received the Nobel Prize in 1999 for having shown the consistency of the theories which today are used to describe nuclear forces – a part of the standard model – but their research programme was actually aiming to demonstrate the consistency of a theory of quantum gravity. They were working on the theories of these other forces only as a preliminary exercise. The 'preliminary exercise' earned them a Nobel Prize, but they did not succeed in showing the consistency of their version of quantum gravity.

The list could go on and would read like a roll of honour of the century's outstanding theoretical physicists. As well as like a catalogue of failures. Very gradually, though, over the course of decades, ideas were clarified and dead ends explored and usefully closed off; techniques and general ideas were strengthened, and results began to build, one developing from another. To mention here the numerous scientists who have contributed to this gradual, slow-moving, collective construction would require a tedious list of names, each one of whom has added a grain or a stone to the process.

I would like to mention just one, who for years held together the threads of this collective research: the remarkable, eternally youthful Englishman – half philosopher and half physicist – Chris Isham. It was when reading one of his articles reviewing the question of quantum gravity that I first became enamoured with the problem. The article explained just why it was so difficult, how our conception of space and time needed to be modified, and gave a lucid overview of all the routes which were being followed at the time, with the results achieved, and difficulties entailed. I was in my third year at university, and the possibility of rethinking space and time from square one fascinated me. This fascination has never diminished. For, as Petrarch sings, 'The wound does not heal due to the weakening of the bow.'